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HAPPY 250TH BIRTHDAY AMERICA!

By Ben Lee

Happy July and happy 250th birthday, America! Seems like it was just yesterday when you were being born and now you're the ripe old age of 250, which in country-years is basically toddlerhood. You're still often wobbly and trying to get your bearings, sometimes stumbling a bit but tenacious enough to get back up again. You're feisty and like to push limits and don't always play perfectly with others but hopefully still learning, growing, evolving and eventually you will figure it all out. But being perfect is never the goal; in fact part of the charm of our country is its youthful unpredictability. It was founded as an experiment in democracy and it's meant to always be changing and adapting to the changing times, while steadfastly holding to its founding principles: life, liberty, the pursuit of happiness. Also, the idea that all men are created equal and the importance of voting in order to make the voice of the people louder than any one ruler. The fragility of democracy reminds me of the tradition of breaking a glass at the end of most Jewish wedding ceremonies. There are dozens of different interpretations but one that makes sense to me is how the glass is like a marriage. It must be treated carefully because once broken, it's impossible to put back together. I think American democracy is like that, too. We might not always like the outcome of every election but we need to respect the power of the process and keep voting to maintain the importance of being heard.

I enjoyed witnessing our neighborhood's democracy in action last month at our annual Homeowners Association Meeting held at Vista del Mar. An election was held for new and recurring board members and I'm always struck by the selflessness of those who choose to volunteer their time to help make our community a better place. I can't even begin to fathom the patience it takes to sit on a board and entertain all the different



opinions, demands, and expectations of a passionate community. The neighbors who choose to give so much of their time to handle the countless tiny details to keep a neighborhood safe and informed are suburban, secular saints. So, I was happy to vote in this particular election because I'm relieved that we have individuals willing to put in the work.

There were a few special guest speakers during the meeting and it's always a good experience to have the opportunity to ask questions directly to our elected officials. Councilwoman Katy Yaroslavsky was just 'rehired' by her constituents and she came prepared to answer a handful of questions pertaining to District 5. She told everyone, "The gulf was too wide between where we are and where we want to be," in terms of overall progress and also added, "Progress is not victory," when it comes to solving the homeless problem. She recognized that lack of parking is one reason why it's so hard to fill vacancies on Pico, shared that the Shelby shelter is likely going to open in October but they're trying to find a new operator

and will look into why there's no street cleaning on certain streets in the neighborhood. Katy also reminded the audience that one member on her staff is assigned to our area so if anyone has pressing issues, we'll likely get an answer quicker from Vanessa Saldana: vanessa.saldana@lacity.org

Lead Officer Chris Baker was out of town so in his place was the Area Captain of West LA, Rich Gabaldon. Captain Gabaldon gave us a rundown of current crime numbers and mentioned how beneficial it has been to utilize the Flock cameras and private patrol companies such as Post. Post guards often arrive on site much quicker and can help police by relaying license plate numbers, descriptions, etc. Gabaldon mentioned the force was spread out pretty thin—there are only 230 officers currently working in the 65 square miles that comprise West LA. He's hoping more recruits join the LAPD and budgets allow for more technology (such as the use of drones) which will help fight crime tremendously.

The last speaker of the evening was Dan Spitz who relayed what's

happening with the restaurant space at Rancho Golf Course. Spitz, famed restaurateur behind, "The Penmar," is hoping to bring a similar upscale/family-friendly vibe to what he's calling, "The Rancho." There are actually going to be a few separate dining spots on the premises. One will be a grab and go that caters to golfers, there'll be a cantina-like patio area for dinner and a clubhouse that will be run by the city. Spitz mentioned that what he's learned from the Penmar is: neighbors are craving community and a central spot to gather, have a good meal, maybe watch the game and not go broke taking the family to dinner. Permits have been pulled, drawings have begun and Spitz said he's hoping to start moving as quickly as possible but he'd be shocked if doors open by 2027. You can visit their website to learn more: the-rancho.com

It was an interesting meeting to attend and really got me interested in democracy at work, now that we're commemorating 250 years of America. However you choose to spend your July 4th holiday this year, I hope you enjoy celebrating the USA's semiquincentennial. Maybe you'll accidentally scald your tongue on a limited-time-only McDonald's fried apple pie, or tie red, white and blue streamers to a bicycle and star in a parade with other neighborhood friends? Perhaps you'll be manning your family's BBQ or attend a fireworks' show. At some point during the festivities, I hope you'll join me in being grateful that we live in this brave country and together we will continue to protect the virtues of democracy.

I tried to find an inspirational, patriotic quote courtesy of our Founding Fathers to close out this article but failed to find anything too succinct and pithy so I'll end it instead with what another fine Ben said about my noble profession (Benjamin Franklin, to be exact), "Well done is better than well said; take action in your real estate ventures." I couldn't have said it better myself!

My featured listings

Cheviot Hills - FOR SALE!



10359 Monte Mar Drive – \$8,995,000
6 Bed / 7.5 Bath 6,635 Sq. Ft.

Cheviot Hills - NEW CONSTRUCTION!



3320 Patricia – \$7,495,000
5 bed / 5 1/2 Bath 5,200 Sq. Ft., 9,275 Sq. Ft. Lot

Rancho Park - FOR SALE!



10525 Almayo – \$1,995,000
3 Bed / 2 Bath 2,144 Sq. Ft.

Cheviot Hills - FOR LEASE!



2890 Forrester Drive – \$21,000 p/mo.
4 Bed / 5 Bath 4,438 Sq. Ft., 7,204 Sq. Ft. Lot

Beverlywood - IN ESCROW!



9015 Beverlywood St. – \$1,270,000
2 Bed / 1 Bath

Beverlywood - SOLD!



1716 S. Durango Ave. –
4 Bed / 3 Bath 2,811 Sq. Ft., 7,110 Sq. Ft. Lot

Pacific Palisades - SOLD OVER ASKING!



16485 El Hito Place – \$2,895,000
4 Beds + Office/Den / 3.5 Bath
2,733 Sq. Ft., 0.62-Acre Lot

Beverlywood - SOLD OVER ASKING!



9124 Beverlywood St. - \$1,795,000
3 Beds / 2 Bath, 1,513 Sq. Ft.

Cheviot Hills - SOLD OVER ASKING!



3388 Manning Ct. – \$2,595,000
4 Bed / 3 Bath 2,388 Sq. Ft., 7,204 Sq. Ft. Lot

Beverlywood happenings



ICE CREAM PARTY

Did you swing by the neighborhood ice cream we threw at my listing on Monte Mar? It was so much fun seeing everyone enjoy a sweet ice cream treat while touring this impressive home. And not only were we giving out ice cream- there was also plenty of new Ben Lee Properties merch (impossible to find a cuter model than Miss Sophie Goss enjoying her new flying frisbee toy, pictured here with her mom, Stephanie). There

were beach balls, chip clips and a whole host of other cool items but don't worry if you didn't get one. I'll have them at other Open Houses throughout the summer. Take a picture of you with any BLP thing and enter our photo contest for your chance to win \$500! Although it'll be hard to beat this one of Sophie! Enter by emailing me a picture and write 'PHOTO' in the subject line: ben@benleeproperties.com. Good luck!



NEIGHBORHOOD LADIES' WINE NIGHT

The incomparable duo Diana Zollicoffer and Theresa Gallagher threw an incredibly festive Ladies' Wine Night on the rooftop of Diana's building. Neighborhood ladies were able to visit and chat with the most

gorgeous view of the city as a backdrop. Our next get-together will be on August 10th at Jackie Shulman's in Cheviot Hills. Please join us! Send me a note and I'll share the details: lillijlee@yahoo.com. Hope to see you there!



MONTHLY FREE DOG FOSTERING WORKSHOP

By Ben Lee

Check out this unique opportunity to learn how to be a foster parent to a needy dog. Melissa Levy (who happens to be my aunt-in-law) will be conducting these free events for anyone interested in learning what it takes to be an animal hero. It's free and open to the public so if you would like to learn more, please see the flyer for more information.

